said he then spent the next two years transporting money and militants from Lashkar, JeM and HuM sent by Qasnami from Karachi to Afghanistan. Masood claims that Qasmani offered to help him reach the Iraqi front in 2005, but he appears to have gotten side-tracked and was arrested that year while recruiting Muslims in India for military training.[139] Notably, Qasmani remained connected to Lashkar while Masood's arrest suggests he returned to work with the group against India after fighting in Afghanistan. This raises questions as to whether the outfit Masood described was a true splinter or something more akin to a spin-off formed by a faction within Lashkar as a means for those militants who prioritized the Afghan jihad to fight there without breaking their ties to the group.

Masood was not the only Lashkar recruit interested in fighting in Iraq. The US invasion of Iraq caused anger throughout Pakistan, as it did in many Muslim countries as well as among Muslims living in Western countries. Not long after American military operations commenced in Iraq, the group held its Defense of the Umma Conference in Islamabad. Hafiz Saeed proclaimed: 'The powerful Western world is terrorizing the Muslims. We are being invaded, humiliated, manipulated and looted. How else can we respond but through jihad?' He declared, 'We must fight against the evil trio, America, Israel and India' and urged militants to fight in Iraq.[140] Lashkar is alleged to have played a role in recruiting jihadis to fight there, a charge that even the ISI did not entirely discount.[141] Lashkar internet postings spoke of an army of fighters bound for Iraq from different countries while an Indian newspaper reported in June 2004 that up to 2,000 Pakistanis had volunteered to fight for the group there.[142] That number is wildly exaggerated, but Lashkar was indeed recruiting for Iraq through JuD offices in 2003 and 2004.[143] Many of those enlisted under the auspices of fighting in Iraq were later steered toward the Kashmir jihad. According to one Pakistani researcher who interviewed recruits at the time, after completing training these recruits were told 'You can volunteer to go to Iraq, but you are obligated to go to Kashmir.' Some of them agreed; others split from the group.[144]

Fighting in Iraq fit with Lashkar's classical jihadi ideology. It was, after all, a Muslim land under occupation. However, Lashkar leaders argued that jihad in Indian-administered Kashmir took priority for the group because of its proximity to that front.[145] Further, ideological preference was not the